

RealWorld Ethical Cases of Social Media Algorithms (Simple Explanation)

Facebook (2021) – Algorithm and Political Division

Simple Explanation:

Facebook's news feed algorithm decides which posts people see first. In 2021, leaked internal documents showed that the system often promoted posts that caused strong reactions, such as anger or arguments. Political posts that created conflict usually got more likes, comments, and shares, so the algorithm pushed them to more users. This sometimes increased political division among people online.

Research Source:

Source / Research: The issue became widely known through the "Facebook Files" investigation by journalists who analyzed Facebook's internal research documents. These documents showed that Facebook researchers themselves found that the algorithm could amplify divisive political content. Reference: Horwitz, J., Seetharaman, D., & Wells, G. (2021). "The Facebook Files." Wall Street Journal Investigation.

TikTok (2020) – Bias in the 'For You Page'

Simple Explanation:

TikTok's "For You Page (FYP)" recommends videos to users based on their behavior. In 2020, concerns were raised that some creators' videos were less visible because of factors like race, appearance, or political opinions. Some lawsuits and studies suggested that certain groups might receive less algorithmic exposure, meaning their content is recommended less often.

Research Source:

Source / Research: Researchers and digital rights groups studied how TikTok's recommendation system works and whether certain creators receive unequal visibility. Example Research: Bandy, J., Diakopoulos, N. (2021). "Curating Quality? Auditing the Algorithmic Power of Platforms." Studies of platform recommendation systems including TikTok.

YouTube (2019) – The 'Rabbit Hole' Effect

Simple Explanation:

YouTube recommends videos to keep users watching longer. Researchers found that the recommendation system sometimes suggests increasingly extreme or controversial content over time. For example, someone watching normal political content might gradually be recommended

more radical videos. This pathway is often called the “rabbit hole effect.”

Research Source:

Source / Research: This issue was studied in a well-known academic paper analyzing large amounts of YouTube data. Reference: Ribeiro, M. H., Ottoni, R., West, R., Almeida, V., & Meira Jr, W. (2019). “Auditing Radicalization Pathways on YouTube.” Proceedings of the ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency.

Twitter / X (2021) – Political Content Amplification

Simple Explanation:

Twitter (now called X) uses algorithms to decide which tweets appear higher in timelines. In 2021, Twitter’s own research team studied whether the algorithm amplified certain political views more than others. The study found that right-leaning political content was sometimes amplified more than left-leaning content in several countries. The exact reason for this was not fully understood.

Research Source:

Source / Research: Twitter conducted an internal algorithm audit to study political amplification. Reference: Twitter Engineering Team (2021). “Algorithmic Amplification of Politics on Twitter.” Official Twitter transparency research report.